

How I Want to Show Up While We Work on Our Relationship

A readiness guide for couples therapy, drawing on Emotionally Focused Therapy, attachment science, and the everyday work of repair.

This is written in the first person, so you can read it as something you are saying to yourself. No one does any of this perfectly, and you are not meant to. It is not a test to pass. It is a way of naming how I want to show up: honest about my own part, aware of how I affect the person I love, and willing to stay in it when we need to repair.

Read it as a promise to yourself. Use it to start a conversation with your partner. And come back to it on the hard days, when the work feels like too much. If a word here is ever unfamiliar, there is a short glossary at therapybrentwood.com/eft-glossary.

Twenty-one things I am committing to

1. I am giving this real time.

Repair rarely works when one foot is already out the door. I will give therapy enough time to actually do something, usually several months of steady effort, rather than treating it as a quick experiment I abandon the first time I get discouraged. While we are in it, I will not hold separation over my partner's head to get my way.

Committing does not guarantee a happy ending, and it does not mean ignoring real safety concerns. It simply means my actions match what I say I want.

2. I am showing up, and actually being here.

I will come to sessions, take part honestly, and not act like my partner is dragging me here. I do not have to feel ready every single time, but I do need to bring some willingness. Change takes repetition, discomfort, and patience. When something hard rises up in me, overwhelm, shame, doubt, defensiveness, I will try to say it out loud instead of disappearing into silence, sarcasm, or a flat refusal.

3. I am working on myself, not just on what is wrong with my partner.

This is not only about what my partner needs to change. I will take an honest look at my own moves: where I get defensive, where I avoid, where I criticize, where I struggle to trust or to say what I need, and how I shut down or lash out when I am stressed. This kind of work asks both of us to notice how we protect ourselves, and how those protections land on the person we love.

4. I am bringing the work home.

Insight that stays in the therapy room does not change anything. I will practice between sessions: slowing down mid-conflict, choosing softer words, offering reassurance, circling back to a hard moment, trying to repair instead of pouring on more fuel. This is where trust actually gets rebuilt. I will do my best to stay flexible with the scheduling, reading, and reflection we agree on.

5. I am treating my partner with respect, and I am done with contempt and cruelty.

Strong feelings do not cancel basic respect. Even in a fight, I will not reach for mockery, humiliation, intimidation, or personal attacks. Contempt, the eye-rolling, the name-calling, the talking down, is one of the clearest signs a relationship is in trouble, because it quietly tells my partner their worth is up for debate. And past contempt lies chronic lying, coercion, threats, aggression, or any kind of abuse. Those are not part of the work. They make the work impossible, and they have to be named and taken seriously. If I am the one causing harm, my job is to stop, own it, and get whatever extra help I need. Respect is the floor everything else stands on.

6. When we start fighting about the details, I will steer us back to what is really going on.

It is easy to get stuck arguing about the facts: who said what, whose memory is right, which version is true. The facts matter, but when we are both flooded, digging into them usually just costs us the connection. I will try to catch us sliding into that and gently point us toward the deeper layer: what each of us is feeling, how we are affecting each other, and what the cycle is doing to us. Coming back to that is not dodging the problem. It is how the problem becomes solvable.

7. I will try to understand my partner's experience, even when I see it differently.

My partner's experience is real, even if I do not share every conclusion or remember it the same way. My job is not to prove my innocence or talk them out of their pain. It is to slow down and understand how the moment actually landed on them. Understanding is not the same as agreeing. I can hold on to my own view and still make real room for theirs. When I cross-examine instead of listen, I usually just deepen the wound.

8. I will risk being open instead of hiding behind my defenses.

When things are tense, most of us reach for cover: defending, criticizing, over-explaining, hitting back, going numb. Those moves usually make sense given what we have been through, but they rarely bring us closer. My job is to set the armor down and name the softer thing underneath it, the fear, the hurt, the loneliness, the longing to be reassured. It is vulnerable, and it can feel exposing. But a secure connection grows when one of us is willing to show what is really going on inside.

9. When my partner opens up, I will handle it with care.

When my partner takes a risk and shows me something tender, I want to meet that moment well. I do not need the perfect words. I need to let them know I am listening and that what is happening to them matters to me. It can sound as simple as, "Thank you for telling me." "I can see why that hurt." "I get why this matters to you." "You matter to me, and I do not want you to be alone with this." These are not lines to perform. They are just ways of being present and reachable.

10. I will name my deeper fears and say what I actually need.

Unspoken fear drives so many fights. Maybe I am afraid of being rejected, or not being enough, or being controlled, abandoned, unseen, blamed, or simply not mattering. I will work on saying those things directly. And I will name what I am really after: closeness, reassurance, respect, comfort, gentleness, steadiness, sometimes space. When all I show is anger or distance, my partner never gets the real message. Naming it clearly is how conflict turns back into contact.

11. I will let repair actually work.

Repair attempts are the small moves that keep a fight from going over the edge: an apology, a softer tone, a kind joke, a hand held out, a pause, a willingness to begin again. My job is to offer them, and to notice my partner's. If I wave off every imperfect attempt, I teach us both to stop trying. The same goes for giving change a chance to land. I will not set tests my partner cannot pass, move the goalposts without warning, or treat one slip as proof that nothing is really happening. I may need more than one apology or more than one conversation, and that is fair. But I have to leave room for honest, repeated effort to count for something. Letting my partner succeed does not mean pretending the trust is already back. It means letting repair do its slow work.

12. I will reassure my partner more often than feels natural.

In a relationship that is hurting, one good moment usually is not enough. Old wounds leave us unsure whether the connection is real or whether it will hold. So I will say it, "You matter." "I love you." "I care." "I want to get this right." "I am here." "We are not enemies", not just once, but often enough that it starts to be believed. Reassurance is not weakness. It is how trust comes back. Trust grows out of a pattern, not a single moment.

13. I will help calm myself instead of leaving all of it to my partner.

My partner can support me, but my partner cannot be my whole nervous system. When I feel myself flooding, pounding heart, clenched jaw, blank mind, I will use what helps: slow breathing, getting grounded, lowering my voice, taking a short break we have agreed on, saying out loud what is happening, and coming back when I can actually be present. Calming myself is not shutting down or pretending I am fine. It is finding enough steadiness inside to stay connected instead of reactive.

14. I will offer steady care, not just care when it is convenient.

A relationship feels safer when support can be counted on. I do not want to only be kind when I am in a good mood or when the problem feels small. My partner needs to know I will show up when it actually matters. Support that comes and goes is its own kind of wound, offering hope and then pulling it away. Steadiness does not mean constant intensity. It means becoming someone my partner can rely on.

15. I will own my impact, not just my intent.

I may not have meant to wound, dismiss, scare, or shut my partner out. But if that is how it landed, the impact still needs to be acknowledged. Owning it builds trust. Getting defensive chips away at it. It can sound like, "I can see how that affected you." "I get why that hurt." "I do not want to keep doing that." "I will work on responding differently." Real accountability is more than an apology. It is understanding the injury, letting it be true, and changing the pattern over time.

16. I will handle therapy language with care.

The ideas we pick up in therapy, triggers, wounds, attachment needs, the cycle, can genuinely help us understand ourselves and each other. They can also quietly drift into something else: a way to excuse my own behavior, to label my partner's reactions, or to win an argument. I will try to catch that in myself when it starts. The point of all this is more honesty and more safety, not more sophisticated blame. And when my partner is brave enough to be vulnerable, I want to hold what they share gently. It is for understanding between us, not ammunition for the next disagreement.

17. I will not use "leaving" to control the moment.

When I am angry, scared, or overwhelmed, I might feel the pull to threaten the whole relationship. I will not use divorce, separation, or moving out as a weapon to win, to scare, or to force my partner into line. Those threats shake the ground we are standing on and make real repair so much harder. If I am genuinely unsure whether I can stay, my job is to bring that into therapy as something to work on, not to throw it like a grenade into a fight.

18. I will speak up early instead of quietly planning my exit.

One of the most damaging things I can do is check out quietly, going through the motions while privately building a case against the relationship. If I am discouraged, disconnected, resentful, or doubting that any of this is helping, I will say so early, while there is still time for us and for the therapy to respond. Going silent and then suddenly leaving is more painful, and less honest, than telling the truth as it happens.

19. I will choose who I lean on carefully.

Support from others matters, but not every voice helps my relationship. I want to be thoughtful about who I confide in. I want people who help me think clearly, stay accountable, and root for real repair, not people who feed my contempt, cheer on impulsive decisions, or nudge me to skip the hard part. This is not secrecy. It is discernment. The right confidants strengthen the work. The wrong ones can lock me deeper into the cycle.

20. I will be patient, because trust comes back slowly.

Change in a relationship is almost never a straight line. There will be progress, setbacks, tender moments, slips back into the old pattern, and another try. I will work on making peace with the fact that a secure connection is built gradually. Impatience can curdle into hopelessness or pressure. Being patient does not mean sitting back. It means staying in the work even when the payoff has not arrived yet.

21. I will remember that my partner is not the whole problem, and neither am I.

Couples in pain often organize everything around blame. I will keep looking honestly at my own part. Even when one of us has caused a real injury, both of us eventually need to understand how the cycle keeps getting fed right now. That does not erase accountability for serious harm. It actually makes repair more possible. When I can see my own pattern without collapsing into shame or firing back, I become someone this relationship can actually use.

Something to come back to

I can return to this whenever the work feels hard, whenever I am tempted to blame, withdraw, or give up, and whenever I need reminding that repair is built out of small, repeated acts of courage, honesty, care, and showing up.

A note on safety. *This guide assumes the relationship is one that can be worked on safely. Where there is abuse, coercive control, ongoing intimidation, or danger, safety comes first. Vulnerability work is not appropriate in an unsafe relationship. Please talk with a qualified clinician or reach out to a domestic violence resource for help.*

If you want to read more

These books are written for general readers, not specialists:

- Johnson, S. (2008). *Hold Me Tight: Seven Conversations for a Lifetime of Love*. Little, Brown Spark.
- Johnson, S. (2022). *The Hold Me Tight Workbook: A Couple's Guide for a Lifetime of Love*. Little, Brown Spark.
- Johnson, S., & Sanderfer, K. (2016). *Created for Connection: The "Hold Me Tight" Guide for Christian Couples*. Little, Brown Spark.
- Kallos-Lilly, V., & Fitzgerald, J. (2021). *An Emotionally Focused Workbook for Couples: The Two of Us* (2nd ed.). Routledge.
- Gottman, J., & Silver, N. (2015). *The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work* (Updated ed.). Harmony Books.